Participatory Research and Practice Innovation learner guide

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Plan a small, ethical, participatory practice inquiry and use the findings with communities to test and improve a service within a professional role.

Use the laws, professional scope, organisational policies and approved referral routes that apply to your setting. This course is educational and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical or legal procedures. All worked cases are fictional. Research notes distinguish published findings from SWEEP teaching examples.

How to use this guide

Read each lesson, explain the worked example in your own words and complete its activity before checking the feedback. The decision points cover the concepts assessed; they are not a substitute for the explanations. Use the separate worksheet to integrate the three lessons. Study time depends on discussion and local adaptation, not a guaranteed completion duration.

Practice case

An advice centre wants to understand why some residents do not return after their first visit. Staff suggest a peer-navigation pilot. Residents want a say in the questions and how findings will be shared. The centre must keep service access separate from any choice to join the inquiry.

Module 1 Practice questions and meaningful participation

Frame an answerable practice question and plan meaningful, voluntary participation.

Frame a question people can influence

Start with an uncertainty that can be explored, not a conclusion to be confirmed. Specify the setting, whose experience matters and what decision the inquiry could inform. For example, asking what makes a return visit difficult leaves more room for learning than asking why residents fail to comply. Agree where community partners can influence questions, recruitment, interpretation and communication, and explain any genuine limits.

Participation must be a meaningful choice. Separate research invitations from decisions about support and avoid suggesting that refusal will affect eligibility. Consider how staff authority, language, timing or compensation could affect participation. Agree co-researcher roles, support, information access and confidentiality before work begins. Keep a reflective note on assumptions and positional influence; reflection makes these influences discussable but does not remove bias.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: residents reshape the centre's question from 'How do we increase compliance?' to 'What makes a second visit useful or difficult?' The team provides a separate way to decline the inquiry without changing access to advice and agrees co-researcher responsibilities.

Decision points

An answerable practice question identifies a specific issue, population or setting and a feasible inquiry; it should not assume its conclusion.

Meaningful participation includes influence over relevant questions and interpretation, with roles and limits agreed in advance.

Separate participation choices from service eligibility; make refusal possible without threatening support, and manage power differences.

Researchers should reflect on how their role and assumptions influence questions, recruitment and interpretation; reflection does not eliminate bias.

Agree co-researcher roles, support, compensation arrangements where applicable, access and confidentiality expectations before tasks begin.

Apply the lesson

Write an answerable question for the advice centre, identify two decisions residents can influence, and explain how someone can refuse without losing services.

Check your reasoning

The question does not presume its answer. Participation roles and limits are clear, refusal is feasible, and the response acknowledges power differences.

Module 2 Ethical inquiry and interpretation

Collect proportionate information and interpret findings without overstating what the inquiry can show.

Interpret proportionate information carefully

Collect only what the question needs. Where feasible, separate contact information used for recruitment from responses used for analysis, and restrict access appropriately. Removing names does not guarantee anonymity: a quotation, job role and location may identify someone together. Review what a reader could infer before sharing detailed accounts, and follow the approved consent and governance arrangements.

Recruitment shapes whose experiences you hear. Explain who was invited, who contributed and which perspectives may be missing. Do not claim that a small or self-selected sample represents every resident. Examine disagreement rather than discarding inconvenient accounts. If outcomes improve after a pilot, consider other changes, participant selection and measurement limits. A before-and-after difference alone does not establish that the pilot caused the improvement.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: only residents who returned answer a feedback form. The team reports their views as those of respondents, not all service users. It considers an approved, non-coercive way to hear from others and removes identifying contextual details from shared examples.

Decision points

Choose the minimum information needed for the question and keep recruitment contacts separate from responses where feasible.

Small groups can be identifiable through combinations of details even when names are removed; review quotations and context before sharing.

Recruitment methods shape whose experiences are represented; describe missing perspectives and avoid generalising beyond the sample.

Conflicting findings should be explored and reported transparently, not removed merely to make a simple story.

A before-and-after change alone does not establish that a pilot caused the result; consider other explanations and design limits.

Apply the lesson

Draft a short limitations paragraph for feedback from a small, self-selected group. Identify a disclosure risk and an alternative explanation for an observed change.

Check your reasoning

The paragraph limits generalisation, preserves conflicting views, recognises indirect identification and separates observed change from causal attribution.

Module 3 Responsible innovation and learning

Plan a bounded, reviewable service pilot with safeguards and a useful feedback loop.

Run a bounded pilot with ethical oversight

Define a pilot's purpose, scope, participants, responsible people and safeguards before starting. Ask the relevant local authority whether research-ethics or other governance review is needed; calling an activity a pilot does not exempt it. Record the determination and obtain required approval before collecting information. Agree conditions for continuing, changing or pausing, including emerging harm or exclusion.

Keep a dated record of changes so findings can be interpreted against the version participants experienced. When a pause condition occurs, use the agreed review route rather than continuing simply to meet a schedule. Return findings in an understandable and accessible form, explain limitations and what decisions followed, and provide a feasible response route. This feedback closes the accountability loop without promising that every suggestion can be implemented.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: the peer-navigation pilot excludes residents who cannot attend daytime meetings. The team uses its review process to pause expansion, discusses alternatives with affected residents, records an approved schedule change and explains the limits of the early findings.

Decision points

Before a pilot, define the scope, participants, risks, responsible people and criteria for continuing, changing or stopping.

A pilot label does not exempt a project from research-ethics or governance review; obtain the relevant determination before data collection.

Stop or pause criteria should lead to timely review when harms or barriers emerge; completing the pilot schedule is not the only priority.

Record adaptations and their timing so later readers know which version participants experienced.

Return understandable findings to participants, explain limits and decisions, and offer a feasible way to respond.

Apply the lesson

Create a one-page pilot brief with scope, oversight, a pause trigger, a change record and a plan for returning findings.

Check your reasoning

The brief identifies required review before data collection, makes pause criteria actionable, records versions and explains how participants will hear and respond to findings.

Assessment preparation

Explain the reasons behind each decision point. Practise with the worksheet using a different situation from the worked examples. The proposed assessment has 15 single-answer questions and a 70% pass threshold, requiring at least 11 correct whole-mark answers. Published settings and availability must be verified in the learning platform; this guide does not establish an assessment ID or certify completion.

Sources and evidence limits

[R4] Cilia Vincenti, S., et al. (2025). Procedural Ethics for Participatory Research: Field-Specific Dilemmas and Recommendations From Researchers, Co-researching Community Partners and the REC Overseeing a Community-Academic ADHD Research Project. International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 24. https://doi.org/10.1177/16094069251364622

Use in this course: A community-academic photovoice project describes collaboration with an ethics committee during protocol design and approval. Limit: A situated account of ethical planning, not a causal evaluation or exemption from local review.

[S4] IFSW (2018). Global Social Work Statement of Ethical Principles. https://www.ifsw.org/global-social-work-statement-of-ethical-principles/

Use in this course: Dignity, participation, confidentiality and professional accountability. Limit: Does not replace applicable law or organisational safeguarding procedures.

The index record is a discovery aid, not a guarantee of quality. Read the source before applying its findings to a different setting. No article endorses this course.